A real pathway to a trade

ACT will end the obsession with university as the default pathway and give young New Zealanders a proper pathway into the trades.

New Zealand's education system has been obsessed with pushing young people towards university. Success has too often been measured by whether a student goes on to get a degree, while trades have wrongly been treated as a second-best option.

It's an outdated attitude that has done a disservice to generations of young New Zealanders. For a bright, ambitious young person, becoming an electrician, builder, mechanic or engineer can be the most intelligent decision they ever make. They can earn while they learn, build valuable skills, avoid taking on a large student loan, and potentially go on to run their own business and employ others.

A university degree can be a great investment. But so can a trade. Neither should be treated as inherently superior to the other. Yet our education system doesn't reflect that reality.

Schools have well-established pathways for students heading to university. Students interested in building, engineering, agriculture, mechanics or other vocational careers face a far less straightforward route. Opportunities depend heavily on which school they attend and whether that school can navigate a maze of funding programmes, eligibility rules and capped places.

The result is that talented students can reach the end of school without ever having a serious opportunity to discover whether a trade might be right for them.

ACT wants to put an end to this university-first mindset and put trades on an equal footing. The Government has already made a good start. The replacement of NCEA will include industry-led subjects with national curricula developed alongside the Industry Skills Boards established at the start of 2026. These subjects will cover areas ranging from building and construction to primary industries.

The Government has also moved money away from Fees Free towards funding for Trades Academies. They provide valuable opportunities, but places remain capped and the programme has traditionally focused on students at risk of disengaging from school.

There are good local examples of what can be done. Ashburton College and Palmerston North Boys' High School have developed strong vocational programmes with local employers and communities. The problem is that schools have largely had to build these systems themselves.

ACT would build a proper national pathway so that choosing a trade is just as straightforward and respected as choosing university.

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01 Funding that follows the student

Schools should not lose money because a student spends part of the week learning somewhere else. Under the current system, a student may spend time with an employer or another training provider. That can reduce the funding available to their school even though the school remains responsible for that student.

This gives schools a financial reason to keep students in the classroom. ACT would protect a school's base and equity funding when a student undertakes approved vocational learning away from school.

Schools would also receive funding for each student enrolled in an approved industry-led subject, for up to two subjects per student each year. The amount would depend on the cost of providing the subject. A course involving workshops, specialist equipment or higher safety requirements would receive more than one that can largely be taught in a classroom. The average top-up is expected to be around $2,000 per student per subject.

Existing funding from STAR, Gateway, Trades Academies and Vocational Pathways would be brought together as part of the new system. This is expected to be funded without needing any new spending outside of Education baselines.

These programmes already support vocational education, but they operate through separate funding streams, rules and application processes. Several are also capped, meaning schools can only offer as many places as the programme allows.

ACT's system would be uncapped. Once a student enrols in an approved industry-led subject, the funding would follow them.

ACT will fund approved industry-led subjects through an uncapped per-student entitlement that follows enrolment.

02 An Industry Award with the same standing as University Entrance

University Entrance gives students, families and universities an easily understood indication that someone is prepared for tertiary education. There is no equivalent for a student preparing to enter industry training.

ACT would create a family of Industry Awards for senior secondary students. An Industry Award would require a student to complete set requirements relevant to that industry alongside completed aligned academic subjects. For example, a student working towards a Primary Industries Award, might combine vocational subjects with agricultural science, biology or business studies.

The award would give employers and training providers a simple indication that a student has already completed relevant learning and is ready to take the next step. It would not become a compulsory entry requirement for an apprenticeship. Employers would remain free to hire whoever they choose.

ACT would work with Industry Skills Boards and NZQA to ensure that credits earned through approved industry-led subjects can be recognised after students leave school and count towards relevant apprenticeship and vocational qualifications, where appropriate.

Students would be able to earn both an Industry Award and University Entrance in the same year. A student who begins preparing for a trade at 16 or 17 should still be able to choose university later.

ACT will establish Industry Awards that recognise preparation for industry training alongside University Entrance.

03 Keep adding new industry subjects

The Government has already identified a range of subjects for Industry Skills Boards to develop as part of the new curriculum. That list should keep changing as industry changes.

Technology is creating new combinations of skills. Electronics and mechatronics are already being incorporated into the curriculum, and other areas will emerge as employers adopt new technology and new industries develop.

Industry Skills Boards are better placed than the Ministry of Education to identify those changes. They should have an ongoing role in proposing and developing new subjects where there is genuine employer demand.

A vocational curriculum designed today will become dated quickly if it is treated as finished.

ACT will have Industry Skills Boards continue developing industry-led subjects as technology and workforce needs change.

A trade should be an equal choice

New Zealand needs skilled builders, electricians, mechanics, engineers and other tradespeople just as much as it needs university graduates.

It's absurd that we've spent decades encouraging bright young people to see university as the ultimate measure of success, while making it unnecessarily difficult for them to pursue practical careers.

An apprenticeship shouldn't be seen as a consolation prize for someone who didn't go to university. For many young people, it will be the better choice.

ACT will remove barriers to meaningful vocational education give students qualifications that recognise their preparation for industry, and give their future employers a greater say in what is taught.

The purpose of education should be to help young people realise their potential, not steer them all down the same path.